

Genesis 1:2 - Hebrew Handwriting & Reading Practice

Learn the word, say every letter name, notice what each mark does, then write it.

וְהָאָרֶץ הָיְתָה תֹהוּ וָבֹהוּ וְחֹשֶׁךְ עַל־פְּנֵי תְהוֹם וְרוּחַ אֱלֹהִים מְרַחֶפֶת עַל־פְּנֵי

Pronunciation: ve-ha-ARETZ ha-ye-TAH TO-hu va-VO-hu, ve-KHO-shekh al-pe-NEI te-HOM, ve-RU-akh Elohim me-ra-KHE-fet al-pe-NEI ha-MA-yim.

Meaning: And the earth was formless and empty, and darkness was over the face of the deep, and the Spirit of God was hovering over the face of the waters.

Word order

#	Hebrew	Transliteration	Pronunciation	Meaning
1	וְהָאָרֶץ	ve-ha'aretz	ve-ha-ARETZ	and the earth
2	הָיְתָה	hayetah	ha-ye-TAH	was
3	תֹהוּ	tohu	TO-hu	formless / unformed
4	וָבֹהוּ	vavohu	va-VO-hu	and void / empty
5	וְחֹשֶׁךְ	ve-choshekh	ve-KHO-shekh	and darkness
6	עַל־פְּנֵי	al-penei	al-pe-NEI	over / upon the face of
7	תְהוֹם	tehom	te-HOM	the deep
8	וְרוּחַ	ve-ruach	ve-RU-akh	and the Spirit / breath / wind
9	אֱלֹהִים	Elohim	eh-lo-HEEM	God
10	מְרַחֶפֶת	merachefet	me-ra-KHE-fet	hovering / fluttering
11	עַל־פְּנֵי	al-penei	al-pe-NEI	over / upon the face of
12	הַמַּיִם	hamayim	ha-MA-yim	the waters

Genesis 1:2 - Word / Phrase 1

וְהָאָרֶץ

Transliteration	ve-ha'aretz		
Pronunciation	ve-ha-ARETZ		
Meaning	and the earth		
From / dictionary form	אָרֶץ	eretz - earth	

Letters and vowel marks

Letter	Name	Sound	What to notice
יְ	Vav	v / vowel helper	Sheva is very short or silent here.
הַ	He (hay)	h	Qamatz usually gives the 'ah/a' sound.
אַ	Aleph	silent / carrier	Qamatz usually gives the 'ah/a' sound.
רְ	Resh	r	Segol gives the 'eh' sound.
ץ	Final Tsadi	ts	No vowel mark on this letter here.

Copy:

Write it yourself:

Genesis 1:2 - Word / Phrase 2

הִיְטָה

Transliteration	hayetah		
Pronunciation	ha-ye-TAH		
Meaning	was		
From / dictionary form	הָיָה	hayah - to be / become	

Letters and vowel marks

Letter	Name	Sound	What to notice
הְ	He (hay)	h	Qamatz usually gives the 'ah/a' sound.
יְ	Yod	y / helper	Sheva is very short or silent here.
תְ	Tav	t	Qamatz usually gives the 'ah/a' sound.
ה	He (hay)	h	He gives the H sound here unless silent at a word ending.

Copy:

Write it yourself:

Genesis 1:2 - Word / Phrase 3

תהו

Transliteration	tohu		
Pronunciation	TO-hu		
Meaning	formless / unformed		
From / dictionary form	תהו	tohu - formlessness	

Letters and vowel marks

Letter	Name	Sound	What to notice
ת	Tav	t	Holam gives the 'oh' sound.
ה	He (hay)	h	He gives the H sound here unless silent at a word ending.
ו	Vav	oo	Shuruk: Vav + dot makes the 'oo' sound.

Copy:

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Genesis 1:2 - Word / Phrase 4

וְבוֹהוּ

Transliteration	vavohu		
Pronunciation	va-VO-hu		
Meaning	and void / empty		
From / dictionary form	בוֹהוּ	bohu - emptiness / void	

Letters and vowel marks

Letter	Name	Sound	What to notice
וְ	Vav	v / vowel helper	Qamatz usually gives the 'ah/a' sound.
בֹּ	Bet	v	Holam gives the 'oh' sound.
הֶ	He (hay)	h	He gives the H sound here unless silent at a word ending.
וֹ	Vav	oo	Shuruk: Vav + dot makes the 'oo' sound.

Copy:

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Genesis 1:2 - Word / Phrase 5

וְחֹשֶׁךְ

Transliteration	ve-choshekh	
Pronunciation	ve-KHO-shekh	
Meaning	and darkness	
From / dictionary form	חֹשֶׁךְ	choshekh - darkness

Letters and vowel marks

Letter	Name	Sound	What to notice
יְ	Vav	v / vowel helper	Sheva is very short or silent here.
חֹ	Chet	kh	Holam gives the 'oh' sound.
שׁ	Shin / Sin	sh	Segol gives the 'eh' sound. Right-hand Shin dot makes SH.
ךְ	Final Kaf	kh	Sheva is very short or silent here.

Copy:

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Genesis 1:2 - Word / Phrase 6

עַל־פְּנֵי

Transliteration	al-penei		
Pronunciation	al-pe-NEI		
Meaning	over / upon the face of		
From / dictionary form	פָּנִים	panim - face / surface	

Letters and vowel marks

Letter	Name	Sound	What to notice
ֵ	Ayin	silent / throat	Patach gives the 'ah/a' sound.
ל	Lamed	l	No vowel mark on this letter here.
—	Maqaf	no sound	Maqaf joins the words; it has no sound.
ֶ	Pe	p	Sheva is very short or silent here. Dagesh makes Pe sound P, not F.
נִ	Nun	n	Tsere gives an 'ay/eh' sound.
י	Yod	y / helper	Yod is Y here, or may help carry an 'ee' vowel.

Copy:

Write it yourself:

Genesis 1:2 - Word / Phrase 7

תְּהוֹם

Transliteration	tehom		
Pronunciation	te-HOM		
Meaning	the deep		
From / dictionary form	תְּהוֹם	tehom - deep	

Letters and vowel marks

Letter	Name	Sound	What to notice
תְּ	Tav	t	Sheva is very short or silent here.
ה	He (hay)	h	He gives the H sound here unless silent at a word ending.
יְ	Vav	v / vowel helper	Holam gives the 'oh' sound.
ם	Final Mem	m	No vowel mark on this letter here.

Copy:

Write it yourself:

Genesis 1:2 - Word / Phrase 8

וְרוּחַ

Transliteration	ve-ruach		
Pronunciation	ve-RU-akh		
Meaning	and the Spirit / breath / wind		
From / dictionary form	וְרוּחַ	ruach - spirit / breath / wind	

Letters and vowel marks

Letter	Name	Sound	What to notice
יְ	Vav	v / vowel helper	Sheva is very short or silent here.
ר	Resh	r	No vowel mark on this letter here.
וּ	Vav	oo	Shuruk: Vav + dot makes the 'oo' sound.
חַ	Chet	kh	Patach gives the 'ah/a' sound.

Copy:

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Genesis 1:2 - Word / Phrase 9

אלהים

Transliteration	Elohim		
Pronunciation	eh-lo-HEEM		
Meaning	God		
From / dictionary form	אלהים	Elohim - God	

Letters and vowel marks

Letter	Name	Sound	What to notice
א	Aleph	silent / carrier	Hatef Segol gives a quick 'eh' sound.
ל	Lamed	l	Holam gives the 'oh' sound.
ה	He (hay)	h	Hiriq gives the 'ee' sound.
י	Yod	y / helper	Yod is Y here, or may help carry an 'ee' vowel.
ם	Final Mem	m	No vowel mark on this letter here.

Copy:

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Genesis 1:2 - Word / Phrase 10

מְרַחֶפֶת

Transliteration merachefet

Pronunciation me-ra-KHE-fet

Meaning hovering / fluttering

From / dictionary form רָחַף rachaf - hover / flutter

Letters and vowel marks

Letter	Name	Sound	What to notice
מְ	Mem	m	Sheva is very short or silent here.
רַ	Resh	r	Patach gives the 'ah/a' sound.
חֶ	Chet	kh	Segol gives the 'eh' sound.
פֶּ	Pe	f	Segol gives the 'eh' sound.
ת	Tav	t	No vowel mark on this letter here.

Copy:

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Genesis 1:2 - Word / Phrase 11

עַל־פְּנֵי

Transliteration al-penei

Pronunciation al-pe-NEI

Meaning over / upon the face of

From / dictionary form פָּנִים panim - face / surface

Letters and vowel marks

Letter	Name	Sound	What to notice
יְ	Ayin	silent / throat	Patach gives the 'ah/a' sound.
ל	Lamed	l	No vowel mark on this letter here.
—	Maqaf	no sound	Maqaf joins the words; it has no sound.
פְּ	Pe	p	Sheva is very short or silent here. Dagesh makes Pe sound P, not F.
נִ	Nun	n	Tsere gives an 'ay/eh' sound.
י	Yod	y / helper	Yod is Y here, or may help carry an 'ee' vowel.

Copy:

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Genesis 1:2 - Word / Phrase 12

הַמַּיִם

Transliteration	hamayim		
Pronunciation	ha-MA-yim		
Meaning	the waters		
From / dictionary form	מַיִם	mayim - water	

Letters and vowel marks

Letter	Name	Sound	What to notice
הַ	He (hay)	h	Patach gives the 'ah/a' sound.
מֶ	Mem	m	Qamatz usually gives the 'ah/a' sound. Dagesh strengthens/doubles this consonant.
יְ	Yod	y / helper	Hiriq gives the 'ee' sound.
ם	Final Mem	m	No vowel mark on this letter here.

Copy:

Write it yourself:

Genesis 1:2 - Put It All Together

Start at the RIGHT edge and move LEFT. Say the letter names and notice the vowel marks as you write.

וְהָאָרֶץ הִיְתָה תֹהוּ וָבֹהוּ וְחֹשֶׁךְ עַל־פְּנֵי תְהוֹם וְרוּחַ אֱלֹהִים מְרַחֶפֶת עַל־פְּנֵי

Pronunciation: ve-ha-ARETZ ha-ye-TAH TO-hu va-VO-hu, ve-KHO-shekh al-pe-NEI te-HOM, ve-RU-akh Elohim me-ra-KHE-fet al-pe-NEI ha-MA-yim.

Meaning: And the earth was formless and empty, and darkness was over the face of the deep, and the Spirit of God was hovering over the face of the waters.

Copy the complete verse: